address China's image problem in India and show it to be a reasonable neighbour in South Asia, thus helping to overcome the trust deficit.

Chinese tactics were to engage in wordplay. Chinese Premier Li Peng told Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao, during the latter's official visit to Beijing in September 1993, that China was willing to take a 'flexible attitude' on the Sikkim Question by proceeding on a more or less realistic basis, and taking into account the interests of the people of India and Sikkim. [15] This was a clever formulation, because by making a reference to the people of Sikkim as distinct from the people of India, it still allowed the Chinese to keep their position on the status of Sikkim open to all possibilities while offering India a glimmer of hope. They had succeeded with such double-speak on the status of Jammu and Kashmir with India in the 1950s, and it had become a part of their playbook. The Chinese signal flexibility through the clever use of optics in order to draw the other party into the process of negotiation, whereafter the second party feels obligated to reciprocate by being flexible on the substantive issue, or of otherwise appearing to be unreasonable. Had the Government of India risen to the Chinese bait by being 'flexible', India would have fallen into their trap.

When the Chinese realized that the Indian side was not rising to their bait of finessing the Sikkim Question in a very roundabout fashion, they decided to leverage India's hope for a more formal Chinese recognition of Sikkim as a part of India, in return for important trade and other concessions. Suggestions were made by the Chinese side, at all levels, at first obliquely and then more directly, about the quid pro quo that China expected, which was the opening of the trade route through Sikkim. China also suggested that the military forces of the two sides could agree on a Border Personnel Meeting point on the Sikkim-Tibet boundary, and the exchange of international mail